

Study Material: Spiritual and Cultural Heritage - Indian Experience

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1. Introduction to Religion, Spirituality and Science

Science

Definition: An organized body of knowledge seeking to understand the physical world through empirical evidence, observation, and experimentation using logical and systematic methods.

Characteristics:

- Fact-based and objective
- Deals with observable and measurable phenomena
- Uses systematic methods
- Practical in nature

Key Concept - Scientism: The flawed belief that science can solve all human problems. Human existential questions often transcend scientific explanation.

Different Sciences: Each field (physics, biology, psychology) is supreme in its sphere. No science claims dominance over others.

Spirituality

Definition: The pursuit of self-knowledge and self-realization through introspection, exploring one's inner dimensions to discover life's purpose.

Focus:

- Addresses existential questions: "Who am I?" "What is the purpose of life?"
- Search for meaning, purpose, and connection with something greater
- Involves meditation and practices for inner peace
- Continuous journey towards self-understanding and moral purification

Religion

- Addresses existential questions through prescribed doctrines, rituals, and communal practices
- Promotes peace, compassion, and moral living
- Offers framework for virtuous lives

Intersection of Science and Spirituality

- Science: focused on external world and objective truths
- Spirituality: delves into subjective experiences and inner self
- Both seek truth and understanding
- Science pursues certainty through experimentation
- Spirituality embraces mystery of existence

2. Peace through Union of Religion/Spirituality and Science

Need for Integration

- Rapid scientific advancement requires spiritual balance
- Essential for value-based education prioritizing peace, ethics, compassion
- Counters violence, aggression, and divisions in society

Value-Based Education Approach

Philosophy: Combining scientific inquiry with spiritual practices for intellectual, emotional, and spiritual development.

Shri Dnyaneshwara's Teaching: "Pursuit of Ultimate Truth is the highest goal of human life" - achievable only through balancing science and spirituality.

Benefits of Integration

- Comprehensive perspective on human existence
- Combines intellectual development with spiritual growth
- Creates peaceful, ethical, compassionate individuals
- Addresses both material progress and spiritual well-being

3. Swami Vivekananda's Views on Education

Early Life and Background

- **Born:** January 12, 1863, Kolkata (as Narendra Nath Datta)
- **Family:** Upper-middle-class Kayastha family
- **Father:** Vishwanath Datta (successful attorney)
- **Mother:** Bhuvaneshwari Devi (deeply devoted)
- **Education:** Western-style university; exposed to Western philosophy, Christianity, science
- Brilliant student with profound spiritual inclinations

Spiritual Journey

Quest for God: Asked various people "Have you seen God?" - found answer in Sri Ramakrishna.

Meeting Sri Ramakrishna (1881):

- Sri Ramakrishna replied: "Yes, I have. I see Him as clearly as I see you, only in a much intense sense."
- Initially skeptical, but gradually attracted to his personality
- Sri Ramakrishna demonstrated essential unity of all religions
- Became Narendra's master, gave him God vision, transformed him into sage and prophet

Social Reform Activities:

- Joined Brahmo Samaj - dedicated to eliminating child marriage and illiteracy
- Determined to spread education among women and lower castes
- Active in Sen's Band of Hope (1881-1884) - discouraged smoking and drinking

Awareness of Life's Mission

After Sri Ramakrishna's death (1886):

- Took vows of sannyasa (1887), becoming Swami Vivekananda
- Traveled throughout India (1890-1893)
- Witnessed appalling poverty and backwardness of masses
- **Key Insight:** Real cause of India's downfall was neglect of the masses

Solution Identified:

1. **Secular Knowledge:** To improve economic conditions (agriculture, village industries)
2. **Spiritual Knowledge:** To infuse faith in themselves, strengthen moral sense

3. **Vehicle:** Education - spreading both types of knowledge

Vedantic Principle Applied: Doctrine of potential divinity of the soul (Atman) - never been taught to masses in practical terms.

World's Parliament of Religions (1893)

Decision to Attend:

- Heard about Parliament to be held in Chicago
- Saw it as right forum for Master's message
- Sought financial help for uplifting masses
- Got inner certitude through meditation at Kanyakumari

At Chicago (September 11, 1893):

- Captivated assembly - described as "orator by divine right"
- Won instant celebrity in America
- Spread Vedanta philosophy for three years in America and England
- Became India's spiritual ambassador

Mission in America:

- Interpretation of India's spiritual culture (Vedantic setting)
- Enriched American religious consciousness through rational, humanistic Vedanta teachings
- Pleaded for understanding between India and New World
- Created healthy synthesis of East and West, religion and science

Return to India and Legacy

Founded Ramakrishna Mission (1897): At Belur Math, Calcutta

- **Ideals:** Self-perfection and service
- Continued to stress these throughout
- Adapted Vedantic ideals to 20th century

In India - Delivered Lecture Series (post-1897):

1. Awaken religious consciousness; create pride in cultural heritage
2. Unify Hinduism by pointing out common bases of its sects
3. Focus educated people on plight of downtrodden masses
4. Expound plan for uplift through Practical Vedanta

Death (Mahasamadhi)

Date: July 4, 1902 (after second Western visit) **Age:** 39 years **Message Before Passing:** "It may be that I shall find it good to get outside my body, to cast it off like a worn out garment. But I shall not cease to work. I shall inspire men everywhere until the whole world shall know that it is one with God."

Legacy:

- Lectures and writings gathered into nine volumes
- Regarded as patriot saint of modern India
- Inspired national consciousness
- Political leaders acknowledged indebtedness to him
- Gave Indians proper understanding of spiritual heritage
- Pointed out drawbacks of Western culture
- Made India a nation with global mission

Key Contributions

1. To India:

- Sense of unity
- Pride in past
- Sense of global mission
- Strengthened nationalist movement

2. To World:

- Presented Hindu spirituality to West
- Promoted Vedanta philosophy
- Emphasized universal brotherhood
- Taught strength-giving, man-making religion

3. Philosophical Approach:

- Service to man as visible manifestation of Godhead
- Stressed universal and humanistic side of Vedas
- Belief in service rather than dogma
- Practical Vedanta application

4. Universal Brotherhood and Peace

Core Philosophy

Ancient Concept: "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" - "The whole world is one family"

Essence:

- View beyond individual differences
- Promote unity and cooperation regardless of race, creed, nationality
- Act with warmth, respect, equality
- Foster global interconnectedness

Swami Vivekananda's Message (1893)

- Introduced concept at World Parliament of Religions, Chicago
- **Message:** Only through love, cooperation, goodwill can true peace and harmony be achieved
- Emphasized need for unity at personal and global levels

Levels of Universal Brotherhood

1. Individual/Personal level
2. Interpersonal level
3. Community level
4. National level
5. Global level

Key Understanding: Logic of interdependence is vital for achieving peace and unity.

True Education

According to Indian philosophy:

- Liberates individuals
- Fosters sense of interconnectedness
- Essential for promoting Universal Brotherhood

Principles of Universal Brotherhood

Recognition:

- Every culture, religion, philosophy holds piece of truth
- Calls for tolerance and mutual respect
- Diversity in thought and belief is natural and beneficial
- Values differences as essential for human progress

Not About Uniformity: About accepting and celebrating differences as fundamental part of human existence.

Religious Perspectives

Sikhism Example:

- Emphasizes fatherhood of God → brotherhood of humanity
- Guru Nanak's teaching: All humans are part of single family under one God
- Treating each other with kindness and respect is intrinsic duty

Implementation

Defining Core Values: Transform values into actionable steps

Active Participation Required:

- Create harmony
- Promote social responsibility
- Contribute to societal development

Balance Needed: Avoid extreme interpretations of liberty and equality that lead to egotism or suppression of individualism.

Universal Brotherhood Day

Date: September 11 (annually) **Commemorates:** Swami Vivekananda's historic Chicago speech **Purpose:**

- Reminder of love, cooperation, recognition of common human values
- Urges youth to appreciate cultural heritage
- Foster sense of unity and responsibility

Practical Application

Not Abstract: Practical guide for action

- Integrate principles into daily life
- Achieve inner peace
- Contribute to global harmony

- Address shared challenges (environmental protection, social well-being)

Goal: Unite humanity by acknowledging common origins and shared goals, working together to build society where all are treated as equals.

5. Dr. Vishwanath Karad's Contributions

Overview

- Founder of MIT World Peace University, Pune, India
- Creator of World Peace Dome (one of largest domes worldwide)
- Symbol of unity and peace among various faiths

Major Projects for Interfaith Harmony

1. World Peace Dome

Location: MIT World Peace University campus, Pune

Significance:

- One of largest domes in world
- Monument dedicated to world peace and interfaith harmony
- Houses statues of great philosophers, saints, scientists, leaders from various religions and cultures

Features:

- Prayer hall
- Library with scriptures from different religions
- Spaces for meditation and reflection
- Venue for international conferences promoting peace
- Contains Philosopher Saint Shri Dnyaneshwar World Peace Prayer Hall (capacity: 3,000)
- Houses World Peace Library below
- Dome has beautiful sunrise image; tiny holes allow light throughout day

2. Vishwaraj Baug (Vishwashanti Ashram)

Location: Near Loni Kalbhor, Pune

Purpose:

- Center for spiritual learning and interfaith dialogue
- Tranquil environment for meditation, reflection
- Learning about various spiritual traditions

3. MIT World Peace University Campus

Features:

- Integrates modern education with traditional values
- State-of-the-art educational facilities
- Auditoriums, conference halls, residential accommodations
- Focus on sustainability and peaceful coexistence

4. Educational Institutions (MIT Group)

Emphasis: Value-based education incorporating peace, ethics, interfaith understanding into curricula

Architectural Style: Blend of traditional and contemporary designs promoting conducive learning environment

5. World Peace Prayer Hall and Library

Purpose: Dedicated to promoting teachings and scriptures of various religions, encouraging visitors to learn about and respect different faiths

6. Bhagwan Gautam Buddha Vihar and Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Smriti Vishwashanti Bhavan

Location: Rameshwar Rui

Style: Japanese Pagoda architecture

Homage To:

- Lord Buddha (Greatest Messenger of Peace)
- Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar (social reformer, architect of Indian Constitution)

7. Vishwadharmi Shriram-Rahim Manavta Setu

Background:

- ~275 years ago: Nizam's armies destroyed ancient Sriram temple
- 1940s: Hindu mobs destroyed Jumma Masjid and Khwaja Zainuddin Dargah during Razakar agitation
- 2011: Hindus and Muslims came together to rebuild destroyed mosque and temple
- Also constructed Buddhist temple in Japanese Pagoda style

Purpose: Celebrate diversity, bridging divide between Hindus and Muslims, honoring Buddha's spirit and Dr. Ambedkar

8. Geeta Bhawan

Thought Projected: All religions are same; ideology of every religion is based on ethos of peace

Features:

- Pictures of people practicing various world religions
- Sense of pervasive calmness
- Peacock figurines - reminder to remain connected with nature

9. Vishwaraj Bandhara Dam

- 720 feet long across river Mula-Mutha at Rajbaug
- 27 mini waterfalls
- 3 midstream temples dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, MahaLaxmi, MahaJal Devta

Vision and Recognition

- Not just physical structures but embodiments of vision for harmonious, peaceful world
- Testaments to lifelong commitment to education, spirituality, interfaith dialogue
- Garnered worldwide recognition and respect
- Initiatives continue inspiring pursuit of global peace and unity

6. Parliament of Science, Religion and Philosophy

Historical Context

Inspiration: 1893 Chicago World Parliament where Swami Vivekananda introduced Hindu philosophy to world

Modern Version: At MIT-WPU, led by Prof. Dr. Vishwanath D. Karad

Core Principle

"Education for Peace": Critical need to cultivate peaceful mindset in upcoming generations

Root Problem Identified

Violence often stems from religious divides, including conflicts between different sects within same faith.

Solution Proposed

Value-Based Universal Education System:

- Integrates scientific and spiritual understanding
- Creates culture of peace through education
- Combines science and spirituality for global harmony

World Peace Centre

Founded: 1996 at MIT, Pune

Role:

- Epicenter for movement
- Engages international scholars and leaders
- Propagates message of unity

Current Reality

Paradox:

- World witnessing overwhelming scientific/industrial developments (AI, digital technology, robotics)
- Simultaneously experiencing violence in name of caste, creed, race, religion
- Despite highest research/technological development, suffering from highest anxiety, depression, frustration, mental health issues

Call to Action

Objective: Create value-based universal education system with appropriate blend of science and religion/spirituality

Goal: Establish holistic, peace-loving, harmonious global community

Purpose: Review, reform, retain core value system for betterment of humanity

Celebration

For last nine years, MIT-WPU celebrates World Parliament of Science, Religion, and Philosophy at MIT World Peace Dome, Loni.

Vision for India

Position India as global leader in pursuit of peace, emphasizing sustainable development guided by spiritual and ethical values.

Programs Focus

Foster human values, tolerance, universal brotherhood, building holistic society nurturing:

- Physical well-being
- Mental well-being
- Intellectual well-being
- Spiritual well-being

Legacy Carried Forward: Swami Vivekananda's vision - educating individuals who contribute positively to global society

7. Value-Based Education System

Definition

Holistic approach emphasizing development of character, ethics, social responsibility alongside academic learning. Cultivates individuals who are morally and spiritually aware, not just knowledgeable.

Ancient Indian Educational System

Foundations:

- Education was more than imparting information
- Nurtured mind, body, and spirit
- Teacher-student relationship was sacred
- Learning involved:
 - **Sravana** (deep listening)
 - **Manana** (contemplation)
 - **Nididhyasana** (meditation)

Outcomes: Fostered self-discipline, humility, close connection with nature

Modern Challenges

Despite increased access to education:

- Societal issues persist: hatred, violence, selfishness
- Question: Why hasn't increased education translated to greater societal harmony?
- **Answer:** Without focus on values, education lacks depth and meaning

Prof. Dr. Vishwanath D. Karad's Vision

Integration Approach: Science and spirituality are complementary, not opposing forces

Value-Based Universal Education System Goals:

- Foster holistic development (physical, intellectual, spiritual)
- Create individuals capable of positive societal contribution
- Aligned with "Non-duality" concept - physical and spiritual aspects interconnected

Components of Modern Value-Based Education

Teaches:

- Critical thinking
- Social responsibility
- Environmental awareness
- Global citizenship

Creates:

- Academically proficient individuals
- Compassionate citizens
- Responsible members of society
- Individuals with moral compass

New Education Policy (NEP) 2020 (India)

Reflects value-based education principles:

- Promotes integrated values
- Ensures moral compass development
- Helps understand role in society

Essential Elements

Virtues to Cultivate:

- Humility
- Non-injury in action, thought, words
- Forbearance in face of adversity
- Dispassion towards sensory pleasures
- Purity of heart and mind
- Love of solitude
- Devotion towards Guru and God

Pessimistic View of Life: Considered necessary condition for spiritual growth

Ultimate Goal

Building peaceful and harmonious society by:

- Nurturing academically successful individuals
- Spiritually enriching individuals
- Creating socially responsible citizens
- Combining ancient wisdom with modern needs
- Creating balanced and just world

Conclusion: Essential for supreme fulfillment, peace, and solving existential problems of life through holistic development.

8. World Peace Dome, Pune

Philosopher Saint Shri Dnyaneshwar World Peace Prayer Hall

Structure: Built around world's largest dome

Capacity: 3,000 people

Design: Conducive to meditation and introspection

Interior Features:

- Beautiful sunrise image etched across dome
- Tiny holes allow light to illuminate sunrise throughout day
- Surrounded by statues of world's greatest philosophers and scientists
- People who shaped thinking across history

World Peace Library

Location: Below Prayer hall

Contents: Philosophical texts from across world

Experience:

- Perusing texts leaves yearning for reflection on musings of great minds
- Feeling compounded when entering Prayer hall
- Serene sunrise above, tranquil atmosphere below
- Perfect avenue for meditation and reflection

Vision

Brilliant design envisioned by Prof. Dr. Vishwanath D Karad - creating space where spiritual reflection and intellectual pursuit merge seamlessly.

9. Peace Lessons from Ramayana

Overview

- One of two national epics of India (along with Mahabharata)
- Constitutes epic literature (Itihasa and Purana)
- Study necessary for correct interpretation of Vedas
- Influencing religious and moral thought for over 2,000 years

Swami Vivekananda's View: Ramayana and Mahabharata are two encyclopedias of ancient Aryan life and wisdom, portraying ideal civilization humanity aspires after.

MacDonnell's Statement: "Probably no work of world literature, secular in origin, has ever produced so profound influence on life and thought of people as Ramayana."

Structure

- **Contains:** 24,000 shlokas (Chaturvinshsahasri)
- **Attributed to:** Sage Valmiki
- **Chapters (Kandas):**
 1. Bala (Adi) kanda
 2. Ayodhya kanda
 3. Aranya kanda
 4. Kiskindha kanda
 5. Sundara kanda
 6. Lanka (Yuddha) kanda
 7. Uttara kanda

Main Story

Key Characters:

- **King Dasaratha** of Ayodhya
- **Three Queens:** Kausalya (eldest), Kaikeyi (second), Sumitra (youngest)
- **Four Sons:** Rama (Kausalya's son), Bharata and Satrughna (Kaikeyi's sons), Laksmana (Sumitra's son)

Plot Summary:

1. Dasaratha arranges Rama's coronation
2. Kaikeyi demands two boons: Rama's banishment, Bharata's installation as king
3. Rama goes to forest; Laksmana and Sita accompany him
4. They live in Panchavati forest haunted by demons
5. Surpanakha (Ravana's sister) makes advances to Laksmana; he chops off her nose
6. Ravana abducts Sita in golden deer trick
7. Rama allies with monkey-king Sugriva
8. Hanumat carries Rama's signet-ring to Sita in Lanka
9. Hanumat's tail set on fire; he burns Lanka
10. Simian followers build bridge across ocean
11. Rama and Laksmana invade Lanka, rescue Sita
12. Rama returns to Ayodhya, anointed King
13. Subjects express dislike of Sita's taint; Rama banishes her
14. Sita takes asylum in Valmiki's hermitage
15. Gives birth to two sons: Lava and Kusa
16. Eventually, Sita prays to Mother Earth; disappears into earth

Origin and Date

- Originated as ballads transmitted orally
- Sung by Sutas (living in royal courts) and Kusilavas (travelling singers, like French troubadours)
- Long period elapsed before written
- Multiple recensions exist (many interpolations)
- **Winternitz's Conclusion:** Extant Ramayana evolved between 4th/3rd century BC and 2nd century AD

Literary Value

Called "Adikavya" (first poetical work)

Origin Story:

- Brigand named Ratnakara saw couple of birds in copulation
- One killed by fowler
- Moved to pity, uttered first verse (shloka)
- Through penance, became sage Valmiki
- As first poet, his epic known as adi-kavya

Intrinsic Qualities:

- **Language:** Limpid, clear
- **Style:** Racy, flowing
- No pedantry or tour de force
- Rarely requires commentary
- Contains romance elements (Sundara-kanda)
- Graphic nature descriptions (Kiskindha-kanda: spring, rains, autumn)

Conforms to Ideal: Poetry should be simple, sensuous, impassioned

Character Delineation:

1. **Rama:**
 - Obedient son
 - True hero with keen sense of honor
 - Devoted husband
 - True king concerned with subjects' pleasure
 - Never remarried after banishing Sita
 - Fraternal affection (laments over Laksmana)

2. Sita:

- Ideal woman
- Sense of duty and love for husband
- Chose arduous forest life over royal comfort
- Faithful despite Ravana's coaxing
- Accepted exile calmly as result of past deeds
- Never accused Rama

Use of Figures of Speech: Various relating to both word and sense

Prosodic Variety: Makes epic pleasant to read

Relationship with Mahabharata

Traditional View: Ramayana preceded Mahabharata

Evidence for Opposite:

1. Panini's grammar mentions Mahabharata characters (Arjuna, Yudhisthira), silent on Ramayana
2. Mahabharata retains old ballad style (Arjuna uvaca, etc.)
3. Ramayana more ornate and polished
4. Mahabharata depicts rougher society (polyandry - Draupadi with five husbands)
5. Mahabharata contains Rama story (Vana-parva), but unclear if from Epic Ramayana or older Rama ballad
6. Harivamsa (Mahabharata supplement) refers to Ramayana
7. Mahabharata contains verbatim verse from Ramayana

Conclusion: Nucleus of Mahabharata may be earlier, but present form of Epic Ramayana appears earlier.

Popularity and Influence

Famous Verse:

■ "As long as mountains and rivers exist on earth, the story of Ramayana will prevail among people."

Impact:

- Children hear story before learning alphabets
- Best medium for inculcating basic moral principles
- Characters became proverbial examples:
 - Rama's regard for father
 - Laksmana's devotion to brother
 - Sita's fidelity to husband

Influence on Literature:

- Shaped ancient Indian literature
- Inspired prose, poetry, drama in Sanskrit
- Vernacular adaptations:
 - Kambana's Ramayana (Tamil)
 - Krttivasi Ramayana (Bengali)
 - Tulasidasa's Ramacaritamanasa (Hindi)
 - Bhanubhakta's Nepali Ramayana
- Buddhist adaptation: Dasaratha-jataka
- Jaina version: Paumchariu
- Persian translations (999 AD)

Beyond India:

- National epic of Nepal (Bhanubhakta's version)
- Ramayana-nataka and Mahiravana-vadha (Sanskrit dramas in Nepal)
- Spread to many foreign countries

Key Teachings and Takeaways

1. Vashishtha: Pioneer of Ramrajya

- Early traits of self-governed, self-disciplined state
- Timely realization for systematic administration
- Kingship governed by values and morals under selfless Rishis' supervision
- Constant efforts (■ ■) for five generations created ideal state (Ramrajya)

2. Occult Love Between King and Subjects

- Ram loved by subjects
- All followed him to exile
- He left while they slept
- Met all sorts of people in society
- Helped Sadhakas, worshippers, inhabitants of Dandakaranya

3. Ram's Work in Exile

- Killed 14,000+ enemies, Asuras, Rakshsas in Dandakaranya

1. Adi Parva
2. Sabha Parva
3. Vana Parva
4. Virata Parva
5. Udyoga Parva
6. Bhishma Parva
7. Drona Parva
8. Karna Parva
9. Shalya Parva
10. Sauptika Parva

- 11. Stri Parva
- 12. Shanti Parva
- 13. Anushasana Parva
- 14. Ashvamedika Parva
- 15. Ashramavasika Parva
- 16. Mausala Parva
- 17. Mahaprasthanika Parva
- 18. Svargarohana Parva

Supplement: Harivamsa

Main Story

Key Characters:

- **Kauravas:** Duryodhana (eldest) and brothers
- **Pandavas:** Yudhisthira (eldest), four brothers, common wife Draupadi

Plot Summary:

- 1. Yudhisthira crowned king
- 2. Duryodhana jealous; defeats Yudhisthira in deceitful dice game
- 3. Terms: 12 years exile + 1 year incognito for Pandavas
- 4. After period, Yudhisthira asks for throne restoration
- 5. Duryodhana refuses without battle
- 6. Gory battle at Kurukshetra
- 7. Kauravas completely routed, lost lives
- 8. Victory mainly with Krishna's help
- 9. Yudhisthira occupied throne
- 10. Pandavas eventually attained heaven

Additional Contents:

- Various legends woven around nucleus:
 - Nala-Damayanti
 - Savitri-Satyavan
 - Dusyanta-Sakuntala
 - Hero-mother Vidula
 - Nahusa
 - Churning of ocean
 - Flood legend
 - King Sivi

Themes: Morality, politics, dharmasastra, philosophical precepts, heroism

Key Takeaways

- 1. **Dedication and Acceptance**
- 2. **Honesty**
- 3. **Philanthropy**
- 4. **Truthfulness** - ■■■■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■ (Truth for welfare)
- 5. **Friendship**
- 6. **Mentoring**
- 7. **Sacrifice** (Example: Abhimanyu)
- 8. **Keeping Word**
- 9. **Values-Based Civilization**

11. Learnings from Bhagavad Gita

Overview

- 700-verse Hindu scripture
- Part of Mahabharata epic
- Topics: necessity of doing duties, importance of detachment, paths of jnana, bhakti, karma, rajayoga for attaining moksha

Context: Arjuna's Dilemma

Setting: Battlefield of Kurukshetra

Conflict:

- Arjuna (skilled warrior prince) morally paralyzed
- Torn between duty (dharma) as warrior and personal values opposing violence
- Must fight against relatives, teachers, friends in opposing army

Solution: Lord Krishna (charioteer/guide) reveals profound spiritual teachings

Core Teachings:

- Concepts of duty (karma)
- Righteousness (dharma)
- Eternal soul (atman)

- Fulfill Kshatriya duty without attachment to outcome
- Recognize impermanence of life
- Understand ultimate reality of soul

Impact: Teachings resonate across centuries; inspire discussions on ethics, duty, spirituality, nature of existence

Major Paths (Yogas)

1. Karma Yoga (Yoga of Action)

Definition: Spiritual path emphasizing selfless action and performing duty without attachment to results

Key Aspects:

- Selfless action without personal gains, desires, attachments
- Focus on dedicating actions to higher purpose or service
- Duty (Dharma): Performing prescribed duties based on skills, responsibilities, station in society
- Active engagement in world while maintaining spiritual attitude
- Integration of spiritual principles into everyday life and work

Nishkama Karma (Desireless Action):

- Perform actions selflessly without motivation by personal desires/gains/outcomes
- Focus on fulfilling duties with dedication while relinquishing attachment to results
- Results influenced by external circumstances and others' actions (beyond control)
- Prioritize dharma and obligations
- Cultivate humility, compassion, equanimity
- Path to spiritual liberation (moksha)
- Transcend desires and attachments through selfless action

2. Bhakti Yoga (Yoga of Devotion)

Definition: Path emphasizing loving devotion towards personal god/deity as means to spiritual realization and union with divine

Key Aspects:

- Cultivate deep, loving relationship with chosen deity
- Characterized by devotion, surrender, heartfelt worship
- Surrender ego and personal desires to divine
- Trust in grace and guidance
- Various worship forms: prayer (sadhana), chanting (kirtan), singing hymns (bhajans), meditation, rituals
- Goal: Union (yoga) of individual soul (jiva) with Supreme Soul (Paramatma)/chosen deity

Qualities of Bhakta:

- Humility
- Compassion
- Devotion
- Unconditional love towards all beings
- See divine presence in everyone and everything

Paths:

- Saguna Bhakti (devotion to deity with attributes/forms)
- Nirguna Bhakti (devotion to formless, attributeless divine)

Goal: Experience profound oneness with divine, transcend dualities, attain spiritual liberation (moksha)

3. Dhyana Yoga (Yoga of Meditation)

Definition: Path focusing on meditation as means to achieve spiritual realization and union with divine

Key Aspects:

- Deep, focused, sustained concentration on chosen object (breath, mantra, visual image, divine form)
- Cultivate inner stillness, concentration, mindfulness
- Quiet fluctuations of mind (chitta vritti)
- Attain inner peace and clarity
- Often integrated with other paths (Hatha, Karma, Bhakti, Jnana Yoga)
- Meditation serves as foundation for spiritual growth

4. Jnana Yoga (Yoga of Knowledge/Wisdom)

Definition: Classical path emphasizing pursuit of knowledge, understanding, wisdom as means to spiritual liberation (moksha)

Key Aspects:

- Intellectual and philosophical inquiry into nature of reality, self (atman), ultimate truth (Brahman)
- Questioning, contemplation, discernment
- Understanding underlying principles of existence

Discrimination (Viveka):

- Distinguish between eternal (unchanging) and transient (changing)
- Differentiate self (atman) from non-self (anatman)
- Differentiate real (Brahman) from unreal (maya)

Study of Scriptures:

- Upanishads
- Vedanta Sutras
- Bhagavad Gita
- Works of Advaita Vedanta scholars (Shankaracharya)
- Guidance on metaphysical truths, nature of self, path to liberation

Self-Inquiry (Atma Vichara):

- Investigate nature of self
- Introspection, contemplation, reflection
- "Who am I?" - realize essence of true identity beyond ego and body-mind complex

Renunciation (Vairagya):

- Detachment from worldly attachments and desires
- Cultivate inner clarity
- Focus on spiritual pursuits
- Reduce distractions and obstacles

Integration: While emphasizing knowledge, integrates aspects of Karma Yoga, Bhakti Yoga, Raja Yoga for harmonized approach

Modern Applications

1. Work-Life Balance

- Teachings on detachment and performing duties without attachment to results
- Better work-life balance
- Focus on task at hand rather than outcome
- More fulfilling professional life

2. Stress Management

- Principles of equanimity and self-discipline
- Tools for managing stress in fast-paced world
- Maintain balance, practice self-control
- Navigate stressful situations effectively

3. Personal Development

- Emphasis on self-knowledge and continuous learning
- Aligns with modern personal development views
- Better self-understanding leads to informed life choices

4. Ethical Leadership

- Teachings on duty and selfless action inspire ethical leadership
- Decisions based on duty rather than personal gain
- More just and effective leadership

5. Daily Spiritual Practice

- Approach daily responsibilities with full dedication and commitment
- Focus on task without worrying about results
- Cultivate sense of purpose and excellence
- View work as worship

6. Treat Every Action as Sacred

- Transform routine tasks into sacred activities
- Whether cooking, cleaning, working - perform with reverence and devotion
- At work, offer skills and expertise to benefit organization and colleagues

12. Peace Philosophers

Saint Shri Dnyaneshwar (1275-1296)

Background

- **Born:** 1275 CE (Ramnavami/Krishna Janmashtami), Apegaon village, Jalna district, Maharashtra
- **Parents:** Vitthalapant (Kulkarni) and Rakhumabai
- **Family:** Four children - Nivruttinath (1273), Dnyaneshwar (1275), Sopan (1277), Muktabai (1279)
- **Death:** 1296 CE (age 21), Sanjeevan Samadhi at Alandi
- **Religion:** Hinduism
- **Philosophy:** Advaita, Varkari
- **Guru:** Nivruttinath (elder brother)

Literary Works:

- Dnyaneshwari (commentary on Bhagavad Gita)
- Amrutanubhav
- Changdev Paasashti
- Haripath
- Abhang devotional poetry

Early Life Challenges

- Father Vitthalapant left family to become sanyasin in Varanasi
- Spiritual teacher RamaShrama instructed him to return to wife
- Orthodox Brahmins saw this as heresy; family persecuted
- Children denied sacred thread ceremony
- Parents gave up lives (jumped into Ganges/Indrayani) as penance for their "sins"
- Still, Brahmins refused to accept children as pure

Intense Desire to Become Monk

Crocodile Incident:

- While bathing in Poorna river, crocodile caught Dnyaneshwar's leg (age 8)
- Asked mother for permission to become monk
- Mother yielded to save his life
- Crocodile immediately released him

Meeting Govinda Bhagavadpada

- Became wandering monk at age 8, searched northward for Guru
- Met Guru Govinda Bhagavadpada
- Initiated into Paramahansa order of Sanyasa (highest order)
- Guru directed him to write commentary on PrasthanTraya (major Upanishads, Brahma Sutras, Bhagavad Gita)
- Mission: Reconcile all conflicting doctrines into all-inclusive Advaita Vedanta Philosophy
- Spread Vedic truths through writings
- Directed to go to Varanasi (age 11)

Life in North India

- Came to Varanasi to spread Advaita Vedanta philosophy
- Began writing commentaries at Manikarnika Ghat
- Scholars visited to gain knowledge
- Argued with spiritual leaders, convinced them to Advaita Vedanta
- Attracted many disciples

At Badrinath (age 12):

- Continued writing Bhashya on PrasthanTraya
- Wrote several treatises
- Visited five Siddha Peeths at Sri Kshetra, Uttarakhand
- Stopped human sacrifices through debate and clarity of thinking
- Had vision of sage Vyasa (as old man)
- Vyasa told him not to leave world yet - must revive Sanathana Dharma

Famous Debates

Buffalo Reciting Vedas (Paithan):

- Man violently lashing old buffalo
- Dnyaneshwar expressed concern
- Brahmins ridiculed him
- Dnyaneshwar placed hand on buffalo's forehead
- Buffalo started reciting Vedic Mantras
- Proved Vedas hold all life sacred as manifestation of Brahman

Changdev Challenge:

- Changdev (accomplished yogi) rode on tiger with magical powers
- Challenged Dnyaneshwar to replicate
- Dnyaneshwar humbled him by riding on moving wall
- Advice given in 65 verses (ChangdevPasashti)
- Changdev became disciple of Muktabai

Visoba Chati Incident (Alandi):

- Orthodox Brahmin ridiculed Sadhus and sages
- Nivrittinath wanted "Mande" (requires frying pan)
- Muktabai couldn't get pan (Visoba informed potters not to give)
- Dnyaneshwar kindled fire inside stomach by Yoga power
- Muktabai baked Mande on his red-hot back

Major Work: Dnyaneshwari

Circumstances:

- Priests of Paithan awarded certificate of purification to four siblings
- Halted at Nevase while returning to Alandi
- Composed Dnyaneshwari in 1290 (age 15-16)
- Commentary on Bhagavad Gita
- Fundamental text of Varkari sect
- Recorded by Sacchidananda (amanuensis)

Unique Features:

- Written in Ovi meter (used for women's songs)
- Four lines: first three or first and third rhyme; fourth line sharp, short ending
- Used vernacular Marathi (not classical Sanskrit)
- Spiritual learning accessible to masses
- Sympathetic towards common people's issues

Other Works:

1. **Amrutanubhava**: Independent philosophical work (at Nivruttinath's request)
2. **Pasaydana** ("Donation of basket full of grains"): Simple request to God for happiness for entire mankind
3. **Yoga Vashishtha**: Experiences in Yoga and Philosophy (Ovi form)
4. ~1200 **Abhangas**: Formulated during pilgrimage to Pandharpur (part of Varkari tradition)

Death of Mother

- Knew through intuition mother was sick
- Reached Kalady just as she was on death-bed
- Composed hymn on Lord Narayana; mother peacefully passed
- Relatives/locals objected to Sanyasin performing funeral rites
- Nobody helped; prevented from collecting firewood
- Carried mother's body on shoulders
- Collected dried plantain stems from backyard
- Performed last rites alone

Philosophy and Teachings

Influences:

1. **Mahanubhava Sect**: Literary style influenced Dnyaneshwar's works
2. **Nath Yogi Tradition**:
 - Initiated by brother Nivruttinath
 - Founded by Gorakshanath
 - Introduced Hatha Yoga system
 - Gahaninath (disciple of Gorakshanath) initiated Nivruttinath
3. **Vitthala Sect**: Universal brotherhood and compassion values

Inherited from Nath Tradition:

- Non-dualistic philosophy (Advaita)
- Usage of vernacular language
- Emphasis on yoga
- Oneness of Vishnu and Shiva

Metaphysics (from Amrutanubhava):

- Examines being/Brahman
- Being is substratum of thought enabling thought and cognition
- Being is prior to thought and concepts
- Distinct from Kantian categories
- Reality is self-evident; doesn't require proof
- Antedates dualistic divisions (knower/known, existence/non-existence, subject/object)

Epistemology:

- Highlights limitations of traditional Pramanas (methods of knowledge)
- Any perception validated only by another deeper understanding
- Rationality of reason transcends reason itself
- Cautions against reliance on scriptural testimony

Ethics (from 13th chapter commentary): **Virtues**:

- Humility
- Non-injury in action, thought, words
- Forbearance in adversity
- Dispassion towards sensory pleasures
- Purity of heart and mind
- Love of solitude
- Devotion towards Guru and God

Saints' Perception: Don't perceive distinctions; identify all objects with their own Self

Karma Yoga:

- Performance of duties
- Acting without egoism
- Renunciation of fruits of actions
- Offering actions to God
- Results in non-action and Self-realization

Metaphysical Framework: World is manifestation of divine, not illusion; creates ethical framework rejecting renunciation, recommending performing duties as worship

Social Philosophy:

- Divine order and moral order are same, inherent in universe
- Recommends protecting and preserving all social institutions
- Humanitarian approach to caste: advocates spiritual egalitarianism

Sanjeevan Samadhi

Final Days:

- After pilgrimage with Namdev
- Returned to Pandharpur
- Honored with feast with contemporary saints (Goroba, Sanvata, Chokhoba, Parisa Bhagwat)
- Desired to enter Sanjeevan Samadhi (deep meditative state)
- Preparations made by Namdev's sons
- 13th day of dark half of Kartik month, age 21
- Entered Samadhi at Alandi

Samadhi Location: Siddhesvara Temple complex, Alandi

Post-Samadhi: According to tradition, brought back to life to meet Namdev when latter prayed to Vithoba

Scientific Verification of Cosmic Energy:

- Dr. Raghunath Narayan Shukla used Scintillation and Bolometer instruments
- Placed 50 feet from Samadhi
- Detected Gamma to radar frequencies
- Used gold, silver, zinc filters - different readings for each
- Highest frequency when Samadhi not covered at all
- Confirms presence of cosmic energy at Samadhi

Klice Nobel (Nobel Laureate):

- Visited Alandi after international symposium
- Embraced Samadhi and two sacred trees
- Explained: Foundation identified 162 cosmic energy spots in India; Alandi was one

Key Teachings on Samadhi

Nirvikalpa/Sanjivan Samadhi Explained:

- Relation between higher awareness and light/pure energy (electromagnetic radiation)
- From Bhavarthadeepika/Dnyaneshwari

Purpose of Life:

- Show common people path of Adhyatma (restricted to supposedly learned Brahmins)
- Fought injustice of hierarchical caste system
- Freed spirituality from hierarchical esotericism
- Made knowledge available to masses

Mission Accomplished:

- Translated Bhagavad Gita from Sanskrit to Marathi
- Created Bhavarthadeepika/Dnyaneshwari
- After fulfilling destiny, chose to unite with supreme soul (Paramatma)

Legacy and Takeaways

Life Lessons:

1. Maximum utilization of human life for mission
2. No age limit for meeting God/achieving spiritual freedom
3. Knowledge and courage
4. Consistency despite hardship
5. Care and concern for mother
6. Understanding of self and others
7. Blend of Pravrutti (worldly life) and Nivrutti (spiritual life)
8. Dedication for mission

Advaitavada Philosophy:

"Born again, death again, birth again to stay in mother's womb! It is indeed hard to cross this boundless ocean of samsara. Oh Murari! Redeem me through Thy mercy."

Still Awake (Jagrut): Message to saint in dream about tree roots troubling him

Referred as "Mauli" (Mother): In Marathi, called everywhere when someone says "Ahomauli!" regardless of gender

Saint Tukaram Maharaj (1609-1681)

Background

- **Birth:** 1609 (Ramnavami)
- **Birthplace:** Dehu, Maharashtra
- **Family:** Father Bolhoba, Mother Kanakai

- **Elder Brother:** Gangadhar (Savji)
- **Caste:** Kshatriya (but counted among shudras during his time)
- **Occupation:** Family were Mahajans (money-lenders), owned farmland, engaged in trade
- **Philosophy:** Bhakti movement, Varkari tradition
- **Devotion:** Vitthala/Vithoba (avatar of Vishnu)

Historical Context

Prevailing Political, Social and Religious Situation:

- Muslim reign firmly entrenched in south
- Portuguese ruled Goa
- Three main Muslim rulers perpetually at war: Adilshah (Bijapur), Nizamshah (Ahmednagar), Kutubshah (Golconda)
- Villages looted recklessly and rendered barren
- Rulers enjoying royal perquisites while subjects lived in abject conditions

Social Degradation:

- Brahmins abandoned pious deportment
- Kshatriyas exploiting Vaishyas
- Forcible conversions common
- Anarchy in every sphere
- Undesirable usurped place of desirable
- Saints robbed of honor
- Society split at many levels
- Religion held no attraction
- Ignorance ruled

People's Longing: Looking forward to new sunrise - witnessed at Dehu

Early Life

Childhood:

- Born to great devotee Bolhoba and wife Kanakai
- Spent in comfort and luxury (prosperous family)
- Initiated into education by Pantoji (village teacher)
- Learned alphabets with pebbles
- Received temporal and spiritual life lessons from father at home
- When Savji refused family business, Tukaram took responsibility
- Received business lessons under father's guidance at Mahajan's Wada (shop)
- Became successful in trade and money-lending
- Praised by public
- Transferred home's pious atmosphere to workplace

Marriages:

- **First wife:** Rakhumabai (chronically afflicted by asthma)
- **Second wife** (Age 13): Jijabai (Avalai), daughter of Appaji Gulwe (famous Pune money-lender)
- Alliance between two affluent families marked pinnacle of prosperity
- House always well-stocked with grains

Series of Tragedies

Age 17: Father and spiritual mentor Bolhoba passed away

Age 18:

- Mother Kanakai passed away
- Brother Savji's wife passed away
- Savji left for pilgrimage, never returned
- Tukaram only 18; whole family responsibility fell on him

Great Famine (1629-1631):

- **1629:** Belated rainfall, crops lost due to surfeit of rain; people held hopes
- **1630:** Drought year
- **1631:** Tremendous excessive drought (culmination of natural calamity)
 - All crops vanished
 - Life everywhere thrown into disarray

Tukaram's Family Losses:

- Lost all cattle
- Money-lending business destroyed
- First wife Rakhumabai died
- Beloved son Santoba died

His Response:

- Not heartless businessman insisting on repayment during suffering
- Set aside personal grief
- Came forward to help famine-hit population generously

Spiritual Transformation

Facing Bereavement:

- Great courage and resilience
- Faced bereavement of near and dear ones
- Faced blows by natural calamities and dwindling fortunes
- Never ran away; not an escapist
- Desirous of conquest in work-a-day life
- Wanted to cull elixir of it all

Search for Truth:

- Set out for Bhandara Mountain in search of truth
- No coming back till finding immortal truth - firm determination
- Wild animals attacked, reptiles troubled
- Remained undeterred
- Perseverance reached fruition

Act of Supreme Sacrifice:

- Asked Kanhoba to bring all documents pledged by borrowers (promissory notes)
- Divided these into two
- Half given back to Kanhoba
- Half consigned to Indrayani waters
- Absolved borrowers of responsibility when own monetary affairs in disarray
- Renounced money-lending business
- **True socialism demonstrated**

New Mission:

- Instead of worldly affairs, renovated family temple (suffered ravages of famine)
- Re-built temple to do keertan
- Went to Bhandara Mountain to prepare discourses in complete solitude
- Daily routine: early morning prayers to Vithoba-Rakhumai
- Abhangs encapsulated essence of ancient Shrutis and Shastras lucidly

Conflict with Rameshwar Bhat

At Dnyandev's Abode, Alandi:

- Did keertan at gate of Dnyandev's abode
- Great scholar Rameshwar Bhat listened
- Surprised to find Bhagavad-Gita and Bhagawat essence in Prakrit language with lucidity
- Scandalized and denounced this novel happening

Bhat's Objection:

- "You are Shudra"
- "Your Abhangs elucidate Vedas' essence - not your right"
- "Sacrilegious to listen from your mouth"
- "Who incited you to undertake such enterprise?"

Tukaram's Response: "Not my own speech, God speaking through me"

Bhat's Order:

- Far from mollified
- Ordered Tukaram to sink verses in river
- "If divine order, God will save them from perishing"

Tukaram's Action:

- Collected all Abhang books
- Tied heavy stone to bundle
- Consigned to Indrayani (like borrowers' promissory notes earlier)
- Temporal matter then, spiritual matter now
- Launched protest in front of temple with great determination
- Do-or-die spirit fully aroused

Divine Intervention:

- Thirteen days passed, nothing happened
- 13th night: Lord God visited as child
- Told Tukaram: He safeguarded Abhang books underwater for 13 days
- Books would resurface next day
- Devout at Dehu received similar divine messages
- Next day: went to Indrayani bank
- All books seen floating on water surface
- **Surprising fact:** Completely untouched by water!
- Swimmers immediately plunged, brought books ashore

Accompanists, Followers and Disciples

Fourteen Accompanists to Keertan (mentioned by Mahipati, 1715-1790):

- Used to recite dhrupad during keertan
1. **Mahadjipant Kulkarni:** Dehu Kulkarni; mentioned by Bahinabai Sioorkar; supervised temple construction
 2. **Gangadhar Mawal:** Talegaon resident; wrote abhangs; documented evidence of service to Tukaram
 3. **Santaji Teli Jagnade:** Chakan resident; wrote abhangs of Tukaram
 4. **Kanhoba:** Tukaram's brother
 5. **Malji Gade:** Tukaram's son-in-law

6. **Kondopant Lohkare:** Lohgaon resident
7. **Gawarsheth Wani:** Sudumbare resident
8. **Malharpant Kulkarni:** Chikhli resident
9. **Abajipan:** Lohgaonkar
10. **Rameshwar Bhat Bahulkar**
11. **Kond Patil:** Lohgaon
12. **Navji Mali:** Lohgaon
13. **Shivba Kasar:** Lohgaon
14. **Sonba Thakur:** Accompanied on mridang

The Departure of Tukaram

Final Words to All:

"Bid thee farewell to me now and each return home now. It's time for me to leave now and beseech all for their blessings. Vithoba has come true for me at the end and Tuka will now disappear bodily."

Historical Documentation:

- Bodily disappeared while reciting name of Lord
- Mentioned in historical documents
- Baloji Teli Jagnade noted: "Tukaram attained Vaikunth in his own body"

The Teachings of Tukaram

Core Principles:

1. **No happiness without God:** No human would attain happiness till there's place for God in life
2. **Mortality reality:** No happiness possible till mortals are part of life
3. **Destiny vs. Divine Grace:**
 - Destiny led Tukaram's worldly affairs to destruction
 - Through divine benediction attained great spiritual height
 - Destiny uncontrollable
 - God abides by restriction of devotee's love
4. **Love and Saints:**
 - Love abundant wherever saints live
 - Perpetual give-and-take of love forms part of enterprise
 - Scholars/knowledgeable have no idea of bliss offered by devotion
5. **Love's Power:**
 - Binds whole society together
 - Does away with all differences and discrimination
 - Makes man's life happy and prosperous
6. **Source of Heavenly Love:**
 - Obtained from remembering Almighty
 - From association with saints
 - Transforms unhappiness and happiness
 - Transforms life itself

Takeaways

Key Life Lessons:

1. **Uplifting the Downtrodden:** Greatness of Saint Tukaram
2. **Honest Living:**
 - Make money through honest means only
 - Amass with detached mind
3. **Good Thought and Conduct:**
 - Teachings center around good thought
 - Impeccable deportment
 - Equality
4. **Speaking Truth:**
 - Never hesitated calling spade a spade
 - Disseminated messages for human welfare
5. **Not an Escapist:**
 - Desirous of conquest in work-a-day life
 - Wanted to cull elixir of it all

Background and Historical Context

Life Period:

- Most agree born during 8th Century (788 AD)
- Lived 32 years, 6 months, 10 days

Birthplace: Kalady, Kerala

Family:

- **Father:** Shiva Guru (poor Nambhoodari Brahmin)
- **Mother:** Aryamba
- Both devotees of Lord Shiva
- Childless for many years

Birth Story:

- Parents went to Trichur, Kerala
- Worshipped Lord Shiva in famous temple
- Soon blessed with son
- Named 'Shankara' - bestower (kara) of happiness (sam)

Historical Context:

- Time of religious and moral chaos in India
- Confusion reigning supreme in sacred land

His Emergence:

- "Jagad Guru" (world teacher)
- Genius par excellence
- Combined all attributes of supernatural being

Comprehensive Attributes:

- Supreme religious reformer
- Theologian
- Illuminated sage
- Yogi and Jnani
- Great mystic
- Practical and comprehensive philosopher
- Staunch devotee
- Gifted poet
- Stupendous writer
- Unparalleled teacher, preacher, debater
- Intellectual giant
- Great ascetic
- Remarkable exponent of Advaita Vedanta
- Powerful spiritual force

Childhood Genius

Remarkable Early Development:

Age 1: One-year-old - started talking clearly

Age 2: Learned all alphabets of mother tongue (Malayalam)

Age 3:

- Started learning Sanskrit alphabets
- Reciting all Kavyas, Puranas, other scriptures

Famous Watermelon Incident:

- Argument among children: how many seeds in watermelon?
- Shankara told friends: as many seeds as there are gods
- When watermelon cut open: only one seed inside
- **Meaning:** Even as small child, knew ultimate supreme is only one

By Age 8 (Remarkable Achievement):

- Learned all Vedas, Upanishads, ancient Hindu scriptures
- Mastered philosophical systems:
 - Nyaya
 - Sankhya
 - Mimamsa
 - Yoga Sutras of Patanjali
- Buddhist, Jaina, Charvaka's Philosophy
- Learned Hatha Yoga, Raja Yoga
- Completed all Sadhanas

By Age 16:

- Wrote Bhashyas and commentaries on:
 - Principal Upanishads
 - Brahma Sutras
 - Bhagavad Gita

Life's Mission

Short Life Span Achievement :

- 32 years, 6 months, 10 days
- Single-handedly overpowered numerous forces opposed to Vedic Sanathana Dharma
- Restored Vedanta (Advaita Vedanta form)
- Convinced all belonging to opposing philosophies
- Walked barefoot throughout India
- Defeated every opponent
- Revived Hinduism to original glory and fame
- Established superiority of Advaita Vedanta over other religions

Intense Desire to Become Monk

Mother's Opposition:

- Wanted to be Sanyasin from childhood
- Mother opposing the idea all the time

The Crocodile Incident:

- One day taking bath in Poorna river near house
- Crocodile caught Shankara's leg
- Tried hard but couldn't free leg from firm grip
- Mother there with him, helpless

Shankara's Proposal:

- Told mother: if she gave permission to become monk, crocodile would leave grip instantly and save his life
- Just to save life, mother yielded to proposal
- In split second, crocodile freed leg and swam away

After Receiving Permission:

- Age 8: Became wandering monk
- Received mother's blessings
- Began search northward for Guru

Meeting with Govinda Bhagavadpada

Finding the Guru:

- After long search, met Guru Govinda Bhagavadpada
- Initiated Shankara into Paramahansa order of Sanyasa (highest order)

Mission Given by Guru:

- Write commentary on PrasthanTraya:
 - Major Upanishads
 - Brahma Sutras
 - Bhagavad Gita
- Reconcile all conflicting doctrines into all-inclusive Advaita Vedanta Philosophy
- Spread Vedic truths through writings

Guru's Directive:

- Go to Varanasi for knowing future course of action
- Shankara only 11 years old at this time

Shankara in North India

At Varanasi:

- Came to spread Advaita Vedanta philosophy
- At secluded place (Manikarnika Ghat)
- Began life's mission: writing commentaries on PrasthanTraya
- Many scholars visited to clear doubts, gain knowledge
- Argued with spiritual leaders from various schools
- Convinced them to Advaita Vedanta doctrine
- Began attracting more disciples

At Badrinath (Age 12):

- Proceeded with disciple Padmapada
- Continued writing Bhashya on PrasthanTraya
- Wrote several treatises
- At Sri Kshetra, Uttarakhand: visited five Siddha Peeths (seats of enlightenment)

At Siddha Peeths:

- Predominance of Tantric methods
- Human sacrifices in name of religion very common
- Great debate between Tantrics and Shankara
- Through clarity of thinking, logical analysis, convincing ability: changed their views
- Tantrics saw futility of human sacrifices
- Agreed to put total stop on these practices

Vision of Sage Vyasa:

- Had vision in Badrinath
- Vyasa appeared as old man
- Shankara only 16; pleaded to shed human form (completed life mission)
- Vyasa told him: not yet right time to leave world
- Must revive Sanathana Dharma
- Make it available to everyone

Famous Debate with Mandana Mishra

About Mandana Mishra:

- Greatest champion of Mimamsa doctrine
- Upheld Vedic ritualism ('Karma Kanda' of Upanishads)
- Emphasized Vedic Karmas/rituals/sacrifices
- Also known as Viswaroopa
- At Mahismathi (present-day Bihar)
- Even parrots discussed 'Shastra' in his house

The Debate:

- Shankara went to Mandana Mishra's home
- Invited him for debate
- Mandana Mishra accepted on condition: loser becomes disciple of winner
- Mandana Mishra's wife Ubhaya Bharati was judge

Judge's Method:

- Threw garlands around both necks
- Whose garland fades first accepts defeat

Debate Outcome:

- Went on continuously for 15 days
- Mandana Mishra accepted defeat

Ubhaya Bharati's Challenge:

- Said Mandana Mishra only one half; she is other half
- To be declared winner, Shankara must defeat her too
- Debate started with Ubhaya Bharati
- Even after 17 days, she couldn't defeat Shankara

Strategy Change:

- Ubhaya Bharati decided to debate on Kamasutra (science of sex and love)
- Shankara (ascetic) had no knowledge of this
- Requested time to learn subject

Parakaya Pravesh (Entering Another's Body):

- Coincidentally, king Amaruka in region just died
- Before cremation, by Yogic powers, Shankara entered king's body
- King's body immediately revived
- As king, Shankara acquired knowledge of marital life, obligations, duties

Final Outcome:

- Now in position to argue with Ubhaya Bharati on Kamasutra
- By then, she declined to debate with Shankara
- As agreed, Mandana Mishra became Shankara's disciple
- Given name: Sureshwaracharya
- Later took charge of Sringeri Mutt

Prophecy:

- Shankara told Sureshwaracharya: later born as Vachaspati
- Would write extensive critical study of his commentaries on Brahma Sutras
- True to prophecy: Vachaspati Mishra wrote sublime sub-commentary
- Named work after his wife: Bhamati

Death of Shankara's Mother

Intuitive Knowledge:

- Knew through intuition mother very sick
- Proceeded to birthplace Kalady, Kerala

Mother's Last Moments:

- Reached Kalady; mother on death-bed
- Sat by her side
- Composed hymn on Lord Narayana
- Mother slowly breathed last peacefully

Funeral Rites Controversy:

- Relatives and Kalady locals objected to Shankara performing funeral rites
- Against traditions of Sannyasins to take part in any rites

- Nobody took part in cremation
- Villagers prevented Shankara from collecting firewood

Shankara's Determination:

- Carried dead body of mother on shoulders (alone)
- Collected dried plantain stems from backyard of house
- Performed last rites of mother all alone

Establishment of Four Mutts

Digvijaya (Victory in All Directions):

- After mother's funeral rites, went on Digvijaya
- Traveled all four directions of India
- Won over scholars from all schools:
 - Sakthas
 - Bhairavas
 - Vaishnavas
 - Jains
 - Madhyamikas
 - Lingayats
 - Pasupathas
 - Kapalikas
- Established supremacy of Advaita Vedanta

Four Mutts Established (Four Corners of India):

1. **Shringeri Mutt / Sharada Peetham** (South India):
 - Location: Shringeri, Karnataka
 - Head: Sureshwaracharya (original name: Mandana Mishra)
2. **Dwaraka Peetham** (Western India):
 - Location: Dwaraka, Gujarat
 - Head: Padmapada
3. **Govardhana Mutt** (Eastern India):
 - Location: Puri, Orissa
 - Head: Hastamalaka (original name: Sanandana)
4. **Joshi Mutt** (Northern India):
 - Location: Badrinath, Uttarakhand
 - Head: Totakacharya (original name: Anandagiri)

Purpose: Each chief disciple appointed as head of respective Mutt

Ascending Sarvajna Peetham

Location: Kashmir (now in POK)

About Sarvajna Peetham:

- Throne of Omniscience
- In temple dedicated to Goddess Sharada/Saraswati (Goddess of knowledge)
- Only wisest of wise one can ascend
- Must have mastered all branches of knowledge

Shankara's Achievement:

- Answered all questions from followers of:
 - Buddhism
 - Jainism
 - Other non-Vedic doctrines
 - Other Vedanta doctrines
- After defeating all scholars, ascended throne of Sarvajna Peetham (throne of transcendental wisdom)

Shankara's Last Days

Multiple Views on Final Days:

View 1:

- Went to Kedarnath (age 32)
- Visited several holy places: Goumukh, Gangotri
- Went to Kailash
- Merged with Lord Shiva

View 2:

- Attained mukti (liberation) at Kedarnath
- Samadhi Mandir behind Kedarnath temple

View 3:

- Spent last days in Dattatreya Guha in Badrinath

View 4:

- Left for unknown place (nobody knows) in 820 AD

Shankaracharya and Vedanta Philosophy

What is Vedanta?:

- Not mere view of Reality
- Also a way of life - spiritual life (not ordinary)

Aim of Vedanta:

- Enable humans to solve existential problems
- Transcend human limitations
- Go beyond suffering
- Attain supreme fulfillment and peace

Advaita Vedanta Core Principle:

- One unchanging Reality alone exists
- Changing entities don't have Absolute existence
- Like ocean's waves: no existence separate from ocean
- Waves rise within ocean; no waves without ocean
- Transient world rises within Reality
- World owes existence to Reality
- World has no independent existence from Reality
- Therefore world said to be unreal

"Advaita" Meaning:

- One and only one
- Non-dual characteristic of Supreme Lord/Almighty God Parmatman
- Creator God doesn't have dualistic nature

Reality and Change:

- What is changing must always be unreal
- Phenomenal world of names and forms ever changing
- Names and forms subject to decay and death
- Hence unreal or impermanent

What is Real?:

- What is constant/permanent must always be Real
- Atman (Eternal, all-pervading Self) ever exists
- Pervades all objects like ether
- If pot broken, ether within and without cannot be destroyed
- If bodies and objects perish, Eternal Self pervading them cannot be destroyed
- It is living Truth and only Reality

Example - Swan:

- Swan lives in water but feathers never soiled
- Similarly, Advaitin lives in world but untouched by its illusion

Shankara's Advaita Philosophy Summary

Famous Verse:

“Brahma Sathyam Jagan Mithya, Jeevo Brahmaiva Na Aparaha”

Meaning:

- Brahman (Ultimate Reality) is Truth
- World is illusion
- Individual soul is not different from Brahman

Takeaways

Key Life Lessons:

1. **Maximum Utilization of Human Life:** For mission/purpose
2. **Knowledge and Courage:** Combined intellectual brilliance with spiritual courage
3. **Consistency Despite Hardship:** Faced all challenges with determination
4. **Care and Concern for Mother:** Performed her last rites despite opposition
5. **Understanding of Self and Others:** Deep wisdom about human nature and Reality
6. **Blend of Pravrutti and Nivrutti:**
 - Pravrutti: Worldly engagement
 - Nivrutti: Spiritual renunciation
 - Harmonized both aspects
7. **Dedication for Mission:** Entire life devoted to reviving Sanathana Dharma

13. Diverse Traditions of Meditation

Ultimate Truth: Journey from Saint Dnyaneshwar to Albert Einstein

The Concept of AUM in Vedic Traditions

AUM (Om) - Sacred Syllable:

- Regarded as sound of universe
- Embodiment of ultimate truth
- Symbol transcending time and space
- Represents entire cycle of existence: creation, preservation, destruction

Structure of AUM:

- **"A"**: Symbolizes beginning
- **"U"**: Continuation
- **"M"**: End
- **Together**: Encompass all that was, is, and will be

Swami Vivekananda's Description:

- Most fundamental sound
- Basis of all other sounds
- Represents full range of sound production
- Starts from root of throat
- Ends at lips
- Universal sound signifying totality of existence

Spiritual Purpose:

- Powerful spiritual tool
- Connects with ultimate reality
- Embodies essence of universe

Saint Dnyaneshwar: Visionary in Spiritual and Scientific Thought

Who Was Saint Dnyaneshwar:

- 13th-century Marathi saint and poet
- Enlightened soul
- Bridged gap between spirituality and science
- Long before modern scientific discoveries

Major Works:

1. **Dnyaneshwari:** Commentary on Bhagavad Gita
 2. **Amrutanubhav:** Nature of self and universe
- Both present profound insights aligning with spiritual and scientific principles

Scientific Insights:

1. Heliocentric Model (Centuries before Galileo):

- Asserted observed motion of Sun is illusion
- Emphasized Sun is stationary
- Earth revolves around Sun
- Anticipated heliocentric model of solar system
- Challenged geocentric view dominating his era

2. Water Cycle Understanding:

Evaporation Description:

- [illegible]

Rainfall Description:

- "■■■■■ ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■"
- Translation: "Later Indra showers it"
- Describes rainfall replenishing Earth

Significance:

- Parallels modern scientific understanding
- Illustrates cycle of water
- Underscores cyclical nature of existence
- Central theme to both spiritual and scientific thought

3. Fire Within Water (■■■■■):

- Poetically explored: fire resides within water
- Aligns with scientific understanding:

- Water composed of hydrogen and oxygen
- Under certain conditions, can produce fire
- Deep understanding of natural world
- Spiritual wisdom anticipating scientific discoveries

Albert Einstein and Scientific Exploration of Ultimate Reality

Who Was Einstein:

- Most celebrated 20th-century physicist
- Revolutionized understanding of universe
- Theory of relativity
- Iconic equation: $E = MC^2$

$E = MC^2$ Explained :

- **E:** Energy
- **M:** Mass
- **C²:** Speed of light squared
- **Meaning:** Mass can be converted into energy and vice versa

Significance:

- Explains immense energy in nuclear reactions
- Suggests at fundamental level: everything made of same "stuff"
- Aligns with spiritual view: all creation interconnected from single source

Quest for Unified Theory:

- Single framework explaining all physical phenomena
- Mirrors spiritual search for ultimate truth
- Believed universe is unified, interconnected whole
- All forces and particles interrelated
- Resonates with spiritual concept of oneness

AUM and $E = MC^2$: Two Expressions of Same Truth

Parallel Between AUM and $E = MC^2$:

- Both represent different facets of same ultimate truth
- **AUM:** Symbol of universe and cycle of existence
- **$E = MC^2$:** Expression of mass-energy equivalence
- Both point to underlying unity of all things

Integration:

- AUM encapsulates spiritual essence of universe
- $E = MC^2$ captures physical reality
- Together: holistic understanding of ultimate reality

Swami Vivekananda on AUM:

- Describes as basis of all sounds
- Foundation of universal vibration

Bridging Spiritual and Scientific Perspectives

Importance of Integration:

- Not just theoretical exercise
- Practical implications for understanding world and our place
- Recognizing interconnectedness of all existence (emphasized by both Saint Dnyaneshwar and Einstein)
- Develop comprehensive worldview encompassing:
 - Seen and unseen
 - Material and spiritual

Holistic Approach:

- Explore both spiritual wisdom and scientific knowledge
- Recognize they're not in opposition
- Two sides of same coin
- Pursuit of truth through:
 - Meditation and introspection
 - Scientific inquiry and experimentation
- Leads to deeper understanding of universe and ultimate reality

Conclusion

Journey Summary:

- From Saint Dnyaneshwar to Albert Einstein
- Testament to enduring quest for ultimate truth
- Transcends boundaries of:
 - Time
 - Culture
 - Discipline

Synthesis:

- Bridging spiritual teachings of AUM with scientific insights of $E = MC^2$
 - Gain richer, more nuanced perspective on nature of reality
 - Invites continuing exploration of both dimensions
 - Fosters greater sense of:
 - Unity
 - Interconnectedness
 - Peace in lives and world
-

Diverse Traditions of Meditation - Part II

Overview of Meditation

What is Meditation?:

- Ancient practice
- Integral to numerous cultures and religions worldwide
- Aimed at achieving:
 - Mental clarity
 - Emotional balance
 - Spiritual growth

Diversity:

- Reflects richness of human traditions
- Each offers distinct techniques and benefits
- Benefits: physical, mental, emotional well-being

1. Mindfulness Meditation (Vipassana)

Origin: Buddhism

Description:

- Most practiced form globally
- Focus on present moment awareness
- Observe thoughts, bodily sensations, emotions without judgment

Practice:

- Breathing exercises
- Body scan techniques
- Anchor awareness in present
- Promotes mental calmness
- Enhanced self-awareness

2. Transcendental Meditation (TM)

Origin: Introduced by Maharishi Mahesh Yogi, India

Practice:

- Silent repetition of specific mantra
- 15-20 minutes twice daily
- Unlike mindfulness: aims to transcend ordinary thought processes
- Reach state of deep rest and relaxation

Benefits:

- Particularly effective for reducing stress
- Improving overall health

3. Zen Meditation (Zazen)

Origin: Zen Buddhism, Japan

Emphasis:

- Proper sitting posture
- Breath control

Goal:

- Observe thoughts without attachment
- Cultivate "no mind" or inner stillness

Practice:

- Seated positions: Lotus or Half-Lotus
- Enhances focus
- Develops calm, stable mind

4. Chakra Meditation

Origin: Hinduism and Buddhism

Focus: Energy centers (chakras) in body

Belief:

- Each chakra corresponds to different aspects:
 - Physical
 - Emotional
 - Spiritual

Practice:

- Visualizing and concentrating on energy centers
- Balance and align chakras
- Use specific colors or symbols
- Breath exercises and affirmations
- Enhance energy flow
- Create harmony within body

5. Sufi Meditation (Muraqabah)

Origin: Islamic mysticism

Aim: Deepen connection with divine

Practice:

- Repetitive prayers or phrases (dhikr)
- Enter meditative state
- Focus on divine presence and love
- Breath control
- Rhythmic chanting
- Create sense of unity and spiritual upliftment

Result: Foster inner peace and devotion

6. Taoist Meditation

Origin: Chinese philosophy of Taoism

Focus: Harmonizing with universal life force (Tao)

Techniques:

- **Microcosmic Orbit:** Visualizing and circulating energy throughout body's meridians
- Energy cultivation
- Internal alchemy
- Achieving balance with nature

7. Trataka (Gazing Meditation)

Origin: Indian yoga tradition

Practice:

- Focusing on single point or object (like candle flame)
- Without blinking
- Enhances concentration and mental clarity
- Trains mind to focus
- Visualize object even after closing eyes

Purpose: Preparatory technique for deeper meditation

8. Yoga Nidra (Yogic Sleep)

Origin: Indian yoga tradition

Description:

- Known as "yogic sleep"
- Deeply relaxing practice

Practice:

- Lie down
- Follow guided instructions
- Gradually move through body scan
- Enter space between wakefulness and sleep
- Release tension and stress from body and mind
- Promote profound sense of relaxation and renewal

9. Sound Meditation (Nada Yoga)

Origin: India

Practice:

- Using sound vibrations to focus mind
- External sounds: singing bowls, gongs
- Internal sounds: chanting
- Direct awareness inward

Goal:

- Tune into vibrations
- Harmonize body and mind
- Enter state of deep concentration and tranquility

Conclusion - Diversity of Meditation Traditions

Significance:

- Highlights depth and richness of human spirituality and culture
- Each practice offers unique pathways to:
 - Inner peace
 - Emotional balance
 - Self-discovery

Purpose:

- Whether seeking relaxation, focus, spiritual connection, or self-awareness
 - Exploring different meditation methods
 - Find practices resonating with needs and lifestyles
 - Lead to more harmonious and fulfilling life
-

Sahaja Yoga Meditation

Introduction and Founder

Founder: H.H. Shree Mataji Nirmala Devi (1970)

About Shree Mataji:

- Scholar of medical science
- Person of divine internal energy
- Result of spiritual inner consciousness
- Studied development of human consciousness and evolution

Her Work:

- Deep practice, penance, foresight
- Conveyed knowledge of:
 - Source of internal and spiritual energy to masses
 - Transmission of internal energy
- Studied effects of divine energy on various aspects of human life in all fields

Institutes Established:

1. International School Dharamshala, Himachal Pradesh, India
2. Rome, Italy
3. Jaipur, Rajasthan

Curriculum Focus:

- Explicit implementation of:
 - Indian lifestyle concept
 - Indian culture
 - Yoga as integral part

Results:

- Masses able to make unprecedented changes in personality
- Due to Sahaja yoga meditation and self-mobilized inner strength

What is Sahaja Yoga?

Core Belief:

- Inspirational structure naturally located inside all of us
- Further evolved by Shree Mataji in 1970

The Process:

- Living process
- Can experience it practically
- Power of God or nature evolved us from Amoeba to human beings

Perspectives:

- One may say: work of divine
- Other may say: work of nature
- Fact remains: human being is one of best compositions
- Best powers of creator seen in creation called human being

Definition:

- Inner revolution
- Brings transformation of humans into spiritual beings
- Gradually manifest sublime qualities:
 - Compassion
 - Generosity
 - Detached, unselfish love
- Live in progressively profound state of bliss and inner peace

Nature of Process:

- Living process
- Gradual transformation of awareness
- Not mental projection or concept
- Like seed sprouts and grows from small shoot into mighty tree
- Sahaja Yoga grows individually and collectively in entirely natural way

Global Movement**Reach:**

- Spiritual movement of global proportions
- People from more than 180 countries
- All age groups
- Diverse religious and social backgrounds
- United by experience of same inner joy and peace

The Kundalini Awakening**What is Kundalini?:**

- Subtle spiritual energy
- Lies dormant in sacrum bone at base of spine
- In three-and-a-half coils

Sacrum Etymology:

- Derived from Greek word for "sacred"

Process:

- Gentle awakening of Kundalini energy
- Inner journey of self-discovery
- Known as Self-realization or Yoga
- Those receiving Realization: "realized souls" or "dweeja" (Sanskrit: "twice-born")

Sahaja Yoga in Educational Institutions**Current Practice:**

- Well known and followed in more than 180 countries

Pune City Schools and Colleges:

- PDEA school
- Jadhavar School and College
- Sihngad Institutes
- VIT school
- MIT World Peace University
- Bharti Vidyapeeth institutes
- SNT

Practice:

- Regular basis for students and faculties
- For whole year

Benefits of Sahaja Yoga Meditation

1. **Protects from illness**
2. **Improved sleeping patterns**
3. **Spiritual awakening**
4. **Sahaja Yoga Chakras:** Activation and balancing
5. **Impact on day-to-day basis:** Practical life improvements
6. **Emotional wellbeing and self-improvement:** Helps in both

Meditation at Home - Resources**Websites:**

- www.sahajayoga.org.in

- www.freemeditation.com

YouTube Channels:

- PRATISHTHAN Pune - YouTube
 - Learning Sahajayoga - YouTube
-

Heartfulness Meditation

Purpose and Core Practices

Purpose:

- Expand consciousness
- From mundane consciousness to divine consciousness

4 Core Practices:

1. Relaxation
2. Meditation
3. Cleaning
4. Inner Connect

Learning Resources:

- Audio and video available at <https://heartfulness.org/in/>

Who Can Practice?

Age Requirement:

- Anyone above 15 years
- Those below 15: can listen to Relaxation anytime

Learning Process:

1. Contact Heartfulness Trainer (<https://heartspots.heartfulness.org/>)
2. Attend 3 sessions (1 session per day on 3 consecutive days)
3. Learn practices
4. Start practice on own with continued support (once a week/fortnight)

Remote Learning:

- Download HeartsApp: <https://heartfulness.org/in/heartsapp/>
- Take sessions from trainer remotely

Practical I - Relaxation

Why Important to Relax?:

- Unwind physically
- Calm down when upset
- Relax tired muscles after hectic day
- Free body and mind when meditating
- Gently close eyes and let inner experiences unfold
- Arrive at effortlessness combined with steady, comfortable posture
- Prepares to plunge into meditation

Origin:

- Derived from Patanjali's Yoga sutras with improvements

Process:

1. Focus on omnipresent energy
2. Healing energy from Mother Earth
3. Imbibe healing energy moving upwards through feet
4. Each organ relaxes
5. Each muscle relaxes
6. Each joint relaxes
7. Proceed from toes to top of head

Trainer's Role:

- Connects with Source
- Touched by:
 - Healing energy ascending from Mother Earth
 - Energy descending from cosmic realms
- Doubly intensifying relaxation process

Flexibility:

- Can narrate instructions for others
- Can do for yourself
- Very simple and gentle
- If skip step, no need to worry

- Main idea: relax completely to extent of dissolving
- Bring attention to heart
- Intensely feel own Centre

Options:

- Practice on own every day
- Ask to be guided by trainer
- Listen to audio on www.heartfulness.org
- Once learned steps, easily guide others

Steps for Relaxation:

1. Sit comfortably, close eyes softly and gently
2. Begin with toes: wiggle them, feel them relax
3. Feel healing energy of Mother Earth move up feet and ankles
4. Up to knees, relaxing lower legs
5. Up legs, relaxing thighs
6. Relax hips, stomach, waist
7. Relax back from top to bottom
8. Relax chest and shoulders, melting away
9. Relax upper arms, forearms, hands to fingertips
10. Relax neck muscles
11. Move awareness to face: jaw, mouth, nose, eyes, earlobes, facial muscles, forehead to top of head
12. Feel whole body completely relaxed
13. Scan entire system; if any part tense/painful/unwell, spend more time immersing in healing energy
14. Move attention to heart, rest there
15. Feel immersed in love and light in heart
16. Remain still and quiet, slowly become absorbed in yourself
17. Remain absorbed as long as you want until ready to come out

After Relaxation:

- Observe how you felt
- Write in journal

Practical II - Meditation

Once We Can Relax: Then can meditate (second Heartfulness practice)

Common Definition:

- Often defined as thinking about one thing continuously

Problem with Definition:

- Often get stuck with definition
- Lose sight of real purpose of meditation

True Purpose:

- Reveals true nature of object meditating upon
- Revelation comes not as thought but as feeling
- Meditation: process shifting from thinking to feeling
- From thinking about Divine to feeling Divine Presence

Journey:

- From complexity of mind to simplicity of heart
- Why many methods involve heart

We Already Know How to Meditate:

- Small child: toy for birthday, group of ants in garden
- Adult: wealth, power, success, loving relationship, higher purpose
- When focus attention on one thing: it is meditation

Important Factor:

- Object of meditation needs to be appropriate for goal
- Universal adage: we become object of our meditation
- Due to power of our own thought

Everything Starts with Thought:

- In Heartfulness Meditation: 'The source of divine light already present within my heart is drawing me inwards'
- But doesn't end with thought
- Just doorway into vast inner universe

Common Experience:

- Many thoughts whizzing around in minds
- Not used to thinking only about one thing
- When start meditating: disappointed by number of thoughts
- Natural and expected that different thoughts arise

Approach in Heartfulness:

- Don't repress thoughts, feelings, emotions
- Left inside: build up like pressure in pressure cooker
- Or lay dormant waiting to germinate

- Better out than in
- Want them to leave
- As they leave, often become aware of presence
- Learn to ignore them as mind lets go
- Don't fight with them
- Simply remind ourselves we're meditating

Transmission (Pranahuti):

- Even Heartfulness Meditation becomes like any other without Transmission
- Transmission is active catalyst for transformation
- Wise to approach as scientist:
 1. Meditate without Transmission
 2. Meditate with Transmission
 3. Compare two experiences

What is Transmission?:

- Speciality of Heartfulness Meditation
- Removes inner complexities/knots in energy field
- Spiritual centres/chakras cleaned or illuminated
- Original cosmic energy/divine essence
- Flows from Guide into hearts of seekers
- Like mother's love flows naturally to children for growth and sustenance

Benefits of Meditation with Transmission:

- Helps transcend from one level to another
- Soar higher into super consciousness
- Dive deeper
- Cleaning subconscious depths of mind
- Primary role of Transmission

How to Experience:

- Take meditation session from Heartfulness trainer
- After completing 3 introductory sessions: enabled to receive transmission when meditating on own

Steps of Heartfulness Meditation:

1. Sit comfortably, close eyes softly and gently, relax
2. Turn attention inwards
3. Have thought: source of divine light already present in heart attracting you from within
4. Do in gentle and natural way
5. No need to concentrate
6. If awareness drifts to other thoughts, gently come back to idea of light in heart
7. Let awareness rest in heart
8. Feel yourself melting into heart
9. All right if relax into deeper state beyond awareness
10. Stay in meditation until feel completed

Duration:

- Fifteen to twenty minutes to begin
- Over days/weeks/months slowly increase to one hour

After Completing Meditation:

- Sit for five minutes
- Observe and savour condition felt within
- Each time unique condition, unique gift
- Hold onto it and cultivate that state
- Slowly get up, carrying condition with you
- Has become part of you

Note Observations:

- Spend few minutes scanning system after meditation
- Observe how you feel and what happened inside
- Write observations in journal
- Examples: 'Experienced nothing today', 'Mind too busy with thoughts'
- Simply write whatever happens (like scientist would)

What You'll Notice:

- Cycles in interest in practice
- Ability to observe within
- Sensitivity to describe different states
- Moods
- Different types of experiences

Resources:

- <https://heartfulness.org/en/simple-heartfulness-practices>
- <https://heartfulness.app.link/heartfulnessapp>

14. Brahma Kumaris and Rajyoga Meditation

About Brahma Kumaris

Official Name: Prajapita Brahma Kumaris Ishwariya Vishwa Vidyalaya

Description:

- Worldwide spiritual movement
- Dedicated to personal transformation and world renewal

Founded:

- 1937 in Hyderabad, Sindh (then part of undivided India)
- By Prajapita Brahma

Current Reach:

- Spread to over 140 countries
- 5 continents of world
- Extensive impact on all sections of society

Status:

- Working as international NGO
- Associated with United Nations Department of Public Relations

Mission:

- Committed to help individuals transform themselves
- Based on understanding of true, spiritual identity
- Transcends mere material existence
- Supports cultivation of deep collective consciousness of peace
- Individual dignity of each soul

Leadership:

- Women-led organization
- Widely known as Brahma Kumaris
- Though founding father: Prajapita Brahma

Historical Leadership

First Administrative Head:

- Mateshwari Jagdamba (fondly known as Mamma)
- Even though founder was Prajapita Brahma

Relocation (1950):

- Spiritual group relocated to India
- Found place in Aravalli Ranges of Mount Abu, Rajasthan
- Seed of spiritual knowledge sown
- Grew gradually
- Organization spreading branches in different parts of country

International Expansion (1971):

- Spiritual knowledge and Raja Yoga spread overseas
- First foreign centre in London

Succession of Leadership:

1. **After Mateshwari Jagdamba (1965):**
 - Ascension in 1965
2. **After Prajapita Brahma (1969):**
 - Ascension in 1969
3. **Rajyogini Dadi Prakashmani:**
 - Appointed next Administrative Head
4. **Rajyogini Dadi Janki:**
 - After Dadi Prakashmani left mortal coil
 - Played pivotal role spreading Godly Message in almost all countries
 - Chief Administrative Head from 2007
 - Led organization with tirelessness and dedication until 2020
 - Ascended at age 104
5. **Dadi Hridaymohini:**
 - Appointed Chief Administrative Head after Dadi Janki
 - Until left mortal coil in March 2021
6. **Dadi Ratanmohini (Present):**
 - Current Chief Administrative Head
 - Age 100
 - Tirelessly and successfully fulfilling responsibilities and services

Objectives

1. Study of Spiritual Knowledge

Focus Areas:

- Knowledge of Soul and its nature
- Awareness of Supreme Being
- Help transform life experiences through ongoing flow of experiences

2. Practice of Rajyoga Meditation

Purpose:

- Step-by-step process to help focus on deep inner strengths and potential
- Reaffirm spiritual identity, inherent goodness, dignity and worth of human being
- Encourage deeper understanding of life's purpose

3. Conscious Assimilation of Virtues

Goals:

- Learning to practice virtues in adverse conditions
- Encourage change of awareness, attitude, vision and behavior within human family
- Encourage deeper understanding of life's purpose

4. Serving Others Spiritually

Aims:

- Create new world order characterized by honesty, sincerity, peace and purity
- Foster spirit of human brotherhood irrespective of:
 - Religion
 - Race
 - Gender
 - Nationality
- Establish relationship between humans and environment based on non-violence

Complexes

Madhuban

Description:

- Original complex created by Founder Father Pitashri Brahma in 1960s
- International Head Quarters of Brahma Kumaris
- Officially known as Pandav Bhawan

Four Major Pilgrimages:

1. Baba's room
2. Baba's Hut
3. History Hall
4. Tower of Peace (memorial dedicated to Baba)

Universal Peace Hall:

- One of first massive halls created by Brahma Kumaris
- Can hold up to 4000 people at time

Experience:

- Must visit space
- Richest experience of peace and calm

Gyan Sarovar

Description:

- Academy for better world
- Residential learning center in Mount Abu
- Dedicated for higher spiritual learning and research in Values and Spirituality

Facilities:

- Accommodation for 800
- State of art auditorium "Harmony Hall" (capacity: 2000)
- Solar kitchen serving 2000 meals per day
- For participants and visitors

Features:

- One of main tourist attractions
- Exemplary landscaping

- Beautiful and enriching Art Gallery
- Several spaces for deep experience of peace, calm, relaxation

Shantivan

Meaning: Forest of Peace

Purpose:

- Holds major international programs
- Meditation camps
- Camps for various wing services

Facilities:

- Accommodation capacity: 20,000 with comfortable arrangements
- Mega Solar Kitchen: can cook 38,500 meals per day
- Diamond Jubilee Hall:
 - State of art hall
 - Accommodates 20,000 audiences at time
 - Record in Limca Books
- Dedicated spaces for deep experience of peace

Brahma Kumaris at the United Nations

Main Status:

- Spiritual headquarters: Mount Abu, India
- Network of centres in more than 140 countries
- International non-governmental organization (NGO)
- Accredited with General Consultative Status with Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

Additional UN Affiliations:

- Associate Status with Department of Public Information (DPI)
- Consultative Status with United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF)
- Observer Status to UN Environment Assembly of UNEP
- Observer Organization to UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC)
- Flagship Member of Education for Rural People (ERP), Food and Agricultural Organization (FAO)

Areas of Work (Promoting UN Purposes and Principles):

- Millennium Development Goals
- Climate Change
- Food Crisis
- Gender Equality
- Global Public Health
- Humanitarian Emergencies
- Human Rights
- Women, Children, Youth
- International Decades and Days

Approach:

- Spiritual trajectory of awareness, attitude, vision and action

Wings of Brahma Kumaris

Sister Organization:

- Rajyoga Education and Research Foundation (RERF)
- Similar aims and purposes
- Accomplished through 20 various wings

Service Model:

- Foundation provides all activities free of charge
- Service to community
- Managed wholly by volunteers

Various Departments:

- Set up various Wings and Departments/Faculties
- Conduct courses for various sections of society

RERF Objectives

1. Establish Rajyoga centres and propagate Rajyoga education
2. Foster Soul-consciousness, Compassion and Kindness
3. Promote literacy and encourage scientific research in Rajyoga
4. Encourage study and practice of universal values:
 - Principles of truth
 - Non-violence

- Spiritual values
- Promote value-based lifestyle

5. Organize Seminars, Workshops, Dialogues and Conferences:

- Bring important personalities from respective fields on common platform
- Broad exchange of ideas
- Infuse fresh thinking towards solving various problems
- Address problems plaguing different sections of society

Social Responsibility of Brahma Kumaris

Focus:

- Providing spiritual education and meditation
 - Free of cost to all sections of society
 - Promoting peace, harmony and positive values
-

Rajyoga Meditation

What is Rajyoga Meditation?

Etymology:

- '**Raja**': means 'ruler'
- '**Yoga**': refers to 'communion'
- **Rajyoga**: divine communion making us self-sovereign

Meditation Etymology:

- From Latin word 'Mederi': means 'to heal'
- **Rajyoga Meditation**: self-healing process

What It Opens:

- Eyes to totally new world - world inside
- Activating dormant inner energies in form of powers
- Nourishing spiritual awareness of:
 - Self
 - Supreme
 - Time
 - World

Results of Exploration:

- Find root of problems
- Find key to solutions
- Start to respond to situations rather than react
- Begin to live in harmony

Simple Method:

- Rise above chattering mind
- Find peace every day
- Know and experience who we really are inside
- Separate from many roles we play and labels given
- Called 'soul consciousness'

Benefits of Soul Consciousness:

- Understanding, valuing, trusting inner self (soul)
- Natural qualities and strengths
- Brings greater self-confidence
- Balance
- Meaning to lives
- Barriers between us and others dissolve
- Barriers between us and Higher Energy/God dissolve

How to Meditate?

Characteristics:

- Easy and natural way
- Without rituals or mantras or postures
- Can be practiced anywhere and anytime with 'open eyes'
- Versatile and universal practice

Learning:

- Getting started needs little explanation

Five-Step Process:

Step 1: Relaxation

- Letting go of tension and stress
- Bringing mind and body into state of calm and peace

Step 2: Concentration

- Use time productively once relaxed
- Focus on thoughts chosen to have

Step 3: Contemplation

- Reflecting deeply on:
 - Myself
 - Inner world
 - Values

Step 4: Realization

- When understanding and feelings combine
- Experience more profound, meaningful reality within

Step 5: Meditation

- Focusing on thought
- Remembering eternal identity
- Re-awakening wonderful state of well-being

Progression:

- Soon arrive at quiet still place with single stride (single thought)
- Won't even need five steps

Where to Meditate?

Flexibility:

- Life already feels full
- Where can we put in meditation activity?
- Beauty of Rajyoga: can fit it anywhere

Location Independence:

- Irrespective of outer space where you find yourself
- Just need 1 step inwards
- Enter world of absolute bliss

Options:

- At home
- In workplace
- While traveling
- Outside or inside
- Quiet among crowds
- Alone or in company
- World Meditation Hour
- Retreats - spaces of calm
- At Brahma Kumaris centres or retreat centres

Learning:

- Visit centres or connect online
- Get equipped to practice

When to Meditate?

Common Belief:

- Most people would like to meditate but don't
- Why? Believe don't have time

Question:

- How and when do busy people make moments to meditate?
- What is good time to meditate and for how long?

Answer:

- Any time is good time to connect with yourself
- That's what meditation is all about
- Need not close activities to start meditation

Key Insight:

- Few moments of self-awareness woven in day-to-day activities
- Creates more time than it takes

Schedule Options:

- As first thing in morning
- At mealtimes
- Throughout day - Traffic Control

- At night
- Anytime

Who Can Meditate?

Universal Access:

- Anyone and everyone who wants to
- Can practice and benefit from Rajyoga Meditation
- Accessible to people of all backgrounds

Practitioners Can Be:

- Any age group
- Any nationality
- Any religion
- Any gender
- Any profession
- Any social strata

Types of People Who Come:

1. **Spiritual Searchers:**
 - Spent time searching for spiritual solutions
 - Find something not found elsewhere
2. **Successful Achievers:**
 - Achieved and gained much in lives
 - Wonder "Is that all there is?"
3. **Those Facing Challenges:**
 - Experienced difficulty and challenge
 - Seek extra power to help them
4. **Deep Spiritual Seekers:**
 - Deep desire to deepen understanding of and connection with Divine
5. **World Servers:**
 - Wish to use own energy and good wishes to bring peace to world
 - Share sense of well-being and contentment with other souls

Benefits of Rajyoga Meditation

1. **Energizes Awareness:**
 - Brings both peace and wisdom to busy mind
2. **Expands Capacity to Love:**
 - Heals broken hearts
 - Improves personal relationships
3. **Dissolves Fears:**
 - Replaces with lightness and freedom from anxiety
4. **Brings Many Powers:**
 - Practice brings into soul many powers
 - Through intellectual communion with God
5. **Harmonizes Energy:**
 - Harmonizes spiritual, mental and physical energy
 - Increases inner strength to lead stress-free life
6. **Enhances Self-Image:**
 - Self-esteem and self-confidence
7. **Overall Well-Being:**
 - Creates sense of overall well-being
8. **Improves Cognitive Functions:**
 - Enhances memory and concentration
 - Mind becomes clearer and more focused
9. **Overcomes Negative Habits:**
 - Helps in overcoming negative habits
10. **Improves Sleep Quality:**
 - Regular practice improves quality of sleep

